How to Write a Field Report

Observation & Data Collection

A Thesis Guide

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2026

Abstract

Fieldwork is where research leaves the library and meets real life. A field report is the written record of that meeting: what the researcher saw, heard and counted in a real place, how the evidence was collected, and what it means. This guide explains how to plan fieldwork, how to observe systematically, how to keep field notes that stay useful months later, how to interview people in the field, and how to turn raw notes into a clear, honest report.

The guide covers the full fieldwork cycle. It begins with planning: choosing a site, gaining permission, preparing equipment and thinking about safety. It then explains observation methods, from watching quietly to taking part in daily life, and the difference between describing what happened and reflecting on what it might mean. Later chapters cover organising data, research ethics, analysing field material, and the standard structure of a field report, with worked examples drawn from fictional settings so that students can see the method without confusing illustration with real data.

The emphasis throughout is practical. Fieldwork rewards the researcher who is prepared, patient and honest about limits. A field report is judged not by how dramatic its findings are, but by whether the reader can trust them: whether the methods are described clearly enough to be checked, whether claims are tied to evidence, and whether the report admits what it could not observe. A student who follows this guide should be able to enter a field site with a plan, leave it with organised evidence, and write a report that examiners can believe.

Keywords: fieldwork, observation, field notes, interviews, data collection, ethics, field report

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How to use this guide: read Chapters 1 and 2 before you choose a site or write a proposal. Read Chapters 3 to 7 while you prepare, and carry Chapters 4 and 6 with you into the field as a reminder of how to record and store what you collect. Use Chapters 8 to 11 while you analyse and write, and Chapter 13 as a final check before submission.

Chapter 1: What Fieldwork Is

Fieldwork means going to the place where the thing you study actually happens, and gathering evidence there, in person. A biologist counts birds in a wetland; a sociologist sits in a market and watches how traders bargain; an education student observes lessons in a classroom; a geographer maps a riverbank after the rains. In every case, the researcher leaves the desk and lets the real world set the evidence. That is what makes fieldwork powerful, and what makes it difficult: the real world does not arrive in neat tables, and it does not wait for the researcher to be ready.

Fieldwork is used when the research question cannot be answered from books, documents or a laboratory alone. If you want to know how a health clinic actually works, you must spend time in one. If you want to know how children learn in a crowded classroom, you must sit in one. Fieldwork is the method of choice whenever behaviour, place and context matter more than controlled conditions. It is common in anthropology, sociology, geography, education, public health, environmental science and business studies, and it appears in many final year projects and theses.

1.1 Fieldwork, surveys and experiments

It helps to see how fieldwork differs from its neighbours. A survey collects the same questions from many people, usually at a distance, and produces numbers that can be compared. An experiment controls conditions so that one variable can be tested. Fieldwork does the opposite: it accepts the mess of real life and studies it closely. The strength of fieldwork is depth and realism — the researcher sees what people actually do, not only what they say they do. Its weakness is that findings from one place cannot always be generalised to another. A good field report states this honestly and lets the depth of the evidence speak for itself.

1.2 What a field report must do

A field report has three jobs. First, it must show what was done: where, when, for how long, with whom, and by what method. Second, it must present the evidence in an organised way, so the reader can follow it without having been there. Third, it must interpret the evidence carefully, separating what was observed from what the researcher thinks it means. A report that does only the first job is a diary. A report that skips to the third is an opinion piece. The discipline of field reporting is keeping all three jobs in balance, and keeping evidence and interpretation visibly apart.

Worked Example: A field question, well and badly framed

Weak: 'Study the market.' It names no question, no focus and no method. Strong: 'How do vegetable sellers in a morning market set and change their prices during the first two hours of trading?' The strong version names the place, the people, the behaviour and the time window. A researcher with this question knows exactly where to stand, what to watch and when to write it down.

[ ] I can state my field question in one sentence.

[ ] I know why fieldwork, not a survey or an experiment, is the right method.

[ ] I know the place, the people and the time window I will study.

[ ] My supervisor has approved the site and the question.

Chapter 2: Planning the Fieldwork: Permissions, Logistics and Safety

Good fieldwork is made before the researcher arrives. A day spent planning saves a week of confusion in the field, and a permission obtained in advance saves a project that would otherwise be stopped at the gate. Planning has four parts: defining the scope, gaining access, arranging logistics, and thinking about safety. None of them can be left to chance, and none of them can be fixed easily once fieldwork has begun.

2.1 Defining the scope

Begin by narrowing the study until it fits the time and resources you actually have. A field study of 'rural health care' is too large for one student in one term. A study of 'how patients are received at one rural health centre on weekday mornings' is

achievable. Decide the site, the days, the hours, the number of observations and the number of interviews before you go. Write these decisions into a short fieldwork plan — one or two pages — and share it with your supervisor. The plan is also your defence if someone later asks why you studied this place and not another: you chose it deliberately, for reasons you can explain.

2.2 Permissions and access

Almost every field site belongs to somebody: a school has a head teacher, a clinic has a manager, a market has a traders' association, a village has community leaders. You need permission from the people responsible, and you need it in writing where possible. Approach them early, explain the study in plain language, say how long you will be there, what you will do, and what will happen to the information. Bring a letter from your university or department, and a copy of your proposal. Never begin observing people who have not been told you are there. If permission is refused, accept it and choose another site; do not observe secretly.

2.3 Logistics: the practical checklist

Fieldwork fails on small things: a dead phone battery, no drinking water, nowhere to sit and write, no transport home at dusk. Visit the site once before the real fieldwork begins, if you can, and note the practical facts: how to get there, how long it takes, where you can work, where the toilets are, whether there is shade or shelter, and what the mobile signal is like. Prepare your equipment the night before each visit: notebook, pens, charged phone or recorder, spare batteries, water, and a bag that keeps paper dry. Keep a small stock of spare notebooks; a field notebook that is lost or soaked is evidence that cannot be recovered.

2.4 Safety and conduct

Tell someone where you are going and when you expect to return, every time you go into the field. Work in daylight unless the study genuinely requires otherwise, and take a colleague with you if the site is remote or unfamiliar. Dress in a way that fits the setting and does not draw attention. Be polite to everyone, even to people who are suspicious of you; you are a guest in their place of work or home. If a situation feels unsafe, leave and return another day. No field data is worth a risk to your safety, and your supervisor would rather hear that you withdrew than that you persisted in an unsafe situation.

Planning task	When to do it	What good looks like
Choose site and scope	4-6 weeks before	One site, one question, written plan agreed
Request permission	3-4 weeks before	Written permission from the person in charge

Reconnaissance visit	1-2 weeks before	Notes on access, facilities, timing, safety
Pilot observation	First field day	Half-day trial; methods and notes tested
Full fieldwork	As scheduled	Daily notes, daily backup, regular supervisor contact

[ ] Scope is written down: site, days, hours, number of observations and interviews.

[ ] Written permission obtained from the person responsible for the site.

[ ] A reconnaissance visit has been made and practical notes taken.

[ ] Equipment is prepared the night before each visit.

[ ] Someone knows where I am going and when I will return.

Chapter 3: Observation Methods: Participant and Non-Participant

Observation is the heart of fieldwork, and it comes in two broad forms. In non-participant observation, the researcher watches without joining in: sitting at the back of a classroom, standing at the edge of a market, counting the people who enter a clinic. In participant observation, the researcher joins the activity: helping in a workshop, eating with a family, working alongside staff. Neither is better in general; each fits different questions, and many studies use both at different stages.

3.1 Non-participant observation

Non-participant observation suits questions about behaviour that can be seen: how long patients wait, how many customers a stall serves in an hour, how a teacher divides time between groups. Its strength is that the researcher disturbs the scene as little as possible, so what is seen is close to what normally happens. Its weakness is that the researcher cannot ask 'why' in the moment, and may misunderstand what is seen. The cure is to combine watching with short interviews afterwards, so that the people observed can explain what the researcher could only guess at.

3.2 Participant observation

Participant observation suits questions about meaning, skill and social life: how apprentices learn a trade, how a community organises a festival, how a team makes decisions. By taking part, the researcher learns things that cannot be seen from the edge — the effort a task takes, the jokes that hold a group together, the unwritten rules. The cost is that participation changes the scene: people behave differently when a researcher joins them, and the researcher may begin to see the group from

the inside and lose the ability to describe it critically. The discipline of participant observation is to take part fully during the day and to step back, in writing, every evening.

3.3 Structured and unstructured observation

Observation can also be structured or unstructured. Structured observation uses a prepared checklist or counting sheet: the researcher records, at fixed intervals, whether a specific behaviour occurred. It produces numbers that can be compared across days or places. Unstructured observation has no checklist: the researcher watches openly and writes down what seems important, following events as they unfold. It produces rich descriptions and surprises. A common pattern is to begin unstructured, to learn what matters, and then to design a structured sheet for the main fieldwork period, so that the most important behaviours are counted systematically.

Method	Best for	Main risk
Non-participant, structured	Counting behaviour, comparing days or places	Missing the reasons behind behaviour
Non-participant, open	Describing a setting for the first time	Too much unfocused material
Participant, open	Learning skills, meanings, social rules	Losing critical distance
Participant, structured	Checking a specific routine from inside	Disrupting the activity being studied

Worked Example: Choosing the method to fit the question

Question: 'How do nurses prioritise patients when a clinic is crowded?' A non-participant observer with a structured sheet could count waiting times and the order in which patients were called. But only a participant observer — or an observer who interviews nurses afterwards — could learn the judgement behind the order. A strong design uses both: counts for the pattern, and interviews for the reasoning.

- [ ] The observation method matches the research question.
- [ ] I know whether I will take part or watch from the edge, and why.
- [ ] A structured sheet is prepared for anything I need to count.
- [ ] I have a plan for checking my interpretations with the people observed.

Chapter 4: Field Notes: Descriptive versus Reflective

Field notes are the raw material of the whole report. Months after the fieldwork, the researcher will have only what the notes contain: memory fades, and it fades fastest for the details that matter most. A good field note is written the same day, in a form the writer can still read and trust months later. The most important discipline in note-taking is the separation of description from reflection. Description says what happened. Reflection says what the researcher thinks about it. Both are valuable, but they must never be mixed in the same sentence, or the reader will never know which is which.

4.1 Descriptive notes: what happened

Descriptive notes record observable facts: who was present, what they did, what was said, in what order, in what place, for how long. They use concrete language and numbers wherever possible. 'Twelve patients waited on benches; the first was called after 22 minutes' is a descriptive note. 'The clinic was inefficient' is not a description — it is a judgement, and it belongs in the reflective part. Write descriptions in the present or past tense, in short sentences, and include direct quotations where a person's own words carry the meaning. A quotation is evidence; a paraphrase is already half interpretation.

4.2 Reflective notes: what it might mean

Reflective notes record the researcher's own thoughts: surprises, puzzles, possible explanations, feelings, and ideas for what to look for next. They are kept in a separate column, a separate page, or a clearly marked paragraph — never interleaved with description. Reflection is where analysis begins: the note 'the nurses seemed to know most patients by name — is this why waiting is tolerated?' is a hypothesis to test on the next visit, not a conclusion. A researcher who reflects every day arrives at analysis with a store of tested ideas; a researcher who does not reflect arrives with a pile of undigested facts.

4.3 The daily routine of note-taking

Write notes in the field in short bursts, and expand them the same evening while the day is fresh. Use a fixed format every day: date, place, time, weather or conditions, who was present, what was observed, and what to follow up tomorrow. Number the pages of a paper notebook and never tear pages out. If you use a phone or laptop, back the file up the same evening to a second location. A lost notebook is a lost study, and no examiner will accept 'I remember it roughly' in place of a dated note.

Worked Example: One observation, written two ways

Weak note: 'The market was busy and chaotic, and sellers were dishonest about prices.' This is judgement, not evidence; a reader cannot check it. Strong note: '09:10. North row, stall 4. A customer asked the price of tomatoes. The seller said 120 per kilo. The customer offered 80. After two minutes of bargaining they agreed on 100. The same exchange happened at stalls 5 and 7 within the next fifteen minutes.' Reflection

(separate paragraph): 'Prices seem to be set by bargaining rather than by a fixed list. Check tomorrow whether the opening price depends on the customer.'

- [ ] Notes are written on the day of the observation, not a week later.
- [ ] Description and reflection are kept visibly separate.
- [ ] Each note has a date, place, time and list of people present.
- [ ] Direct quotations are marked as quotations.
- [ ] Notes are backed up every evening; pages are numbered.

Chapter 5: Interviews in the Field

Observation shows what people do. Interviews show what they think, why they do it, and how they understand their own world. A field study that uses only observation can describe behaviour; a study that adds interviews can explain it. Interviews in the field are usually informal and semi-structured: the researcher has a list of topics to cover, but follows the conversation where it leads, and asks new questions when something unexpected appears. This flexibility is the strength of field interviewing, and it is also its discipline — the researcher must cover the topics without turning the conversation into a questionnaire.

5.1 Preparing an interview guide

An interview guide is a short list of open questions, usually six to ten, arranged from easy to sensitive. Start with facts and experience — 'How long have you worked here?' 'Walk me through a typical morning' — before moving to opinions and problems. Avoid questions that can be answered yes or no, and avoid leading questions that suggest the answer you want. 'Do you think the new system is bad?' leads the witness; 'How has the new system changed your work?' lets the person answer in their own words. Pilot the guide with one or two people before the main interviews, and revise any question that is misunderstood or produces only a shrug.

5.2 Conducting the interview

Choose a place where the person feels comfortable and will not be overheard, and keep the interview short — twenty to forty minutes is usually enough. Begin by explaining the study again, confirming consent, and asking whether recording is acceptable. If the person refuses recording, take notes instead and write them up immediately afterwards. Listen more than you speak, and allow silences: people often give their most useful answer after a pause, when they have had time to think. Take brief notes during the interview — key phrases, striking words, topics to return to — but keep your eyes on the person, not on the page. A field interview is a conversation, not an interrogation.

5.3 Recording and transcribing

If permission to record was given, check the recorder before you begin, place it where it will pick up both voices, and test it for a few seconds. After the interview, label the file at once with the date, a participant code, and the place; never leave a

file named 'Recording 1'. Transcribe as soon as possible, while you still remember the context. A full word-for-word transcript is ideal for a small number of interviews; for a larger number, a careful summary with key passages transcribed in full is acceptable, provided the choice is stated in the report. Keep transcripts and recordings in a secure place, and use participant codes, never real names, in any file that leaves your computer.

Worked Example: A leading question and a fair one

Leading: 'You must find the new timetable very stressful, don't you?' The teacher can only agree or disagree, and most people will agree to be polite. Fair: 'How has the new timetable affected your working day?' The fair version produced, in our fictional example, a detailed answer about double periods, preparation time and the loss of a free period on Tuesdays — information the leading question would never have revealed.

[ ] Interview guide prepared: six to ten open questions, easy to sensitive.

[ ] Consent confirmed and recording permission asked before starting.

[ ] Recorder tested; files labelled with date and participant code at once.

[ ] Notes written up the same day; key quotations transcribed word for word.

[ ] Real names kept out of transcripts and working files.

Chapter 6: Collecting and Organising Data

Fieldwork produces many kinds of evidence at once: handwritten notes, audio files, photographs, counting sheets, documents, maps and sketches. Without a system, this material becomes a pile that cannot be searched when writing begins. The solution is a simple, consistent system, set up before the first field day and used without exception. The system has three parts: a way of naming files, a place to store them, and a daily routine for backing them up and writing a short summary of what was collected.

6.1 Naming and labelling everything

Give every item a name that tells you what it is without opening it: date, place, type and a short description. '2026-03-04_clinic_waiting_counts' is a useful name; 'notes2' is not. Use the same date format everywhere, so that files sort in order. In a paper notebook, write the date and place at the top of every page, and keep a contents page at the front listing the dates and topics. In the report, every piece of evidence should be traceable to a dated note or file, so that a reader — or an examiner — can see where each claim came from.

6.2 The fieldwork diary and the data log

Two documents hold the system together. The fieldwork diary is a daily record, kept by the researcher, of what was done: where you went, whom you met, what you observed, what went wrong, and what you plan to do next. The data log is a simple list of everything collected: every note, interview, photograph and document, with its date and file name. Together they form the audit trail of the study. If a question

arises months later — 'Did you observe on a Friday or a Saturday?' — the diary and the log answer it in seconds. Keep both up to date daily; a log reconstructed from memory at the end of fieldwork is unreliable.

6.3 Counting and measuring in the field

Some field data are numbers: how many people, how long, how often, how much. Numbers are collected with a counting sheet or a tally, designed in advance and tested on the first day. Decide the categories before you count, and keep them the same throughout the study; changing the categories halfway makes the early and late counts incomparable. Record the conditions alongside the numbers — the day of the week, the weather, whether a special event was happening — because a count without its conditions cannot be interpreted. Where measurements are taken, for example of water depth or plot size, record the instrument used and the unit of measurement, and repeat a sample of measurements to check their consistency.

Data type	How it is stored	How it is labelled
Field notes	Dated notebook; scanned copy	Date, place, page number
Interviews	Audio file + transcript	Date, participant code, place
Counting sheets	Paper sheet; spreadsheet copy	Date, place, time period
Photographs	Dated folder, original files	Date, place, subject, direction
Documents	Photocopy or scan, original returned	Source, date obtained

- [ ] A file-naming system is in place and used for every item.
- [ ] Fieldwork diary and data log are updated every day.
- [ ] Counting categories are fixed before the main fieldwork begins.
- [ ] Every item is backed up in a second location each evening.
- [ ] A spare notebook, pen and charged battery are always in the bag.

Chapter 7: Ethics in the Field

Fieldwork involves real people in their real lives, and that brings responsibilities that cannot be delegated to a form. Research ethics in the field rests on four principles: respect for the people studied, informed consent, confidentiality, and honesty about what the research can and cannot do. Most universities require ethical approval before fieldwork begins, and the approval process is part of the planning described in Chapter 2. But approval on paper is not the same as ethical conduct in the field; the researcher must make ethical judgements every day, often without time to consult anyone.

7.1 Informed consent, in plain language

Informed consent means that people understand what the study is, what you will ask of them, and what will happen to the information, and that they agree freely. Explain this in plain language, in the person's own language where possible, and without jargon. Written consent is best where people are comfortable with forms; where it is not appropriate — for example, with people who do not read confidently — verbal consent, recorded in your notes with the date and the words used, is acceptable if your ethics approval allows it. Consent is not a single event: if a person becomes uncomfortable during an interview, stop, and offer to end it or to leave out what was said. People may also withdraw consent later, and their data must then be removed.

7.2 Confidentiality and anonymity

Protect the identity of the people you study. Use codes instead of names in notes, transcripts and the report, and remove details that could identify a person — a rare job title, an unusual family situation, a distinctive address. This matters most in small communities, where a description like 'the only female head teacher in the district' identifies a person at once. Keep raw data in a secure place, do not discuss individual participants with outsiders, and do not share photographs that show faces without explicit permission. When in doubt about whether a detail could identify someone, leave it out.

7.3 Honesty, harm and benefit

Be honest with participants about who you are and why you are there; never pretend to be a customer, a patient or an inspector in order to observe. Do not promise benefits you cannot deliver — a report will not, by itself, repair a road or raise a salary — and do not raise expectations you cannot meet. Think about whether the research could cause harm: could a published description embarrass a person, damage a business, or create trouble with an employer? If so, change the description or omit it. Finally, give something back where you can: a copy of the finished report, a summary in plain language, or a thank-you to the people and the institution that hosted you.

Worked Example: An ethical problem, handled well

Fictional situation: during a classroom observation, a researcher notices a teacher

treating one group of pupils unfairly. The researcher does not intervene in the lesson, which would disrupt the class and betray the observer's role. Instead, the researcher records the observation factually, raises the matter afterwards with the supervisor, and writes the report in a way that describes the pattern without naming the teacher or the school. The report discusses the issue as a finding about classroom practice, not as an accusation against a person.

- [ ] Ethical approval obtained before fieldwork began.
- [ ] Consent explained in plain language and freely given.
- [ ] Participant codes used; identifying details removed.
- [ ] Photographs of people taken only with explicit permission.
- [ ] A plan exists for sharing the finished report with the host community.

Chapter 8: Analysing Field Data

Analysis begins long before writing, in the reflective notes described in Chapter 4, and it continues throughout fieldwork: each evening's reflection suggests what to observe the next day. Formal analysis, after fieldwork ends, has three steps: organising the material, finding patterns, and testing those patterns against the evidence. The work is slow and careful, and it is where a field report is won or lost. A report with rich notes and weak analysis is a disappointment; a report with modest notes and careful analysis can be genuinely useful.

8.1 Organising the material

Begin by reading everything — all notes, transcripts, counting sheets — from start to finish, without trying to analyse. Then sort the material by theme, using the research question as the guide. A simple method is coding: writing a short label in the margin each time a topic appears, for example 'waiting time', 'bargaining', 'staff shortage'. The same label will appear many times, and the collection of passages under one label becomes the evidence for that theme. Keep a list of the codes and their definitions, and revise the list as new themes appear. Whether you code on paper or with software, the principle is the same: every claim in the report must be traceable to the passages it rests on.

8.2 Finding patterns and testing them

Once the material is coded, look for patterns: things that happen repeatedly, things that happen together, and things that do not happen. Count where counting helps — how often a behaviour occurred, in what conditions — and quote where words carry the meaning. Then test each pattern: does it hold across different days, different people, different places in the site? Look deliberately for exceptions and for evidence that contradicts the pattern. A pattern that survives this testing is a finding. A pattern that does not is a hypothesis that the evidence could not support, and it should be reported as such, honestly, rather than quietly dropped.

8.3 Triangulation: checking one source against another

Triangulation means checking a finding against more than one kind of evidence. If observation suggests that waiting times are long, do the counting sheets agree? If interviews suggest that patients accept waiting because they trust the staff, does the observation of patient behaviour support that? If three sources point the same way, the finding is strong. If they disagree, the disagreement itself is informative and should be reported, with the possible reasons examined. Triangulation is the field researcher's answer to the question 'How do you know?' — and it is one of the first things an examiner will look for.

Analysis step	What you do	What it produces
Read through	Read all notes and transcripts	A sense of the whole picture
Code	Label passages by theme	Themes with their evidence
Count and compare	Count occurrences; compare days and groups	Patterns and exceptions
Triangulate	Check each pattern against other sources	Findings you can defend
Write up	Present findings with evidence	The findings chapter

- [ ] All notes and transcripts have been read through at least once.
- [ ] A code list exists and every claim can be traced to coded passages.
- [ ] Patterns have been tested across days, people and places.
- [ ] Contradictory evidence has been sought, not avoided.
- [ ] Each finding is supported by more than one kind of evidence where possible.

Chapter 9: Structure of the Field Report

A field report follows a standard structure that examiners expect, and following it makes the report easier to read and easier to mark. The structure below is used in most universities, but always check your department's regulations first: the required order, the word count and the referencing style are set by your university, not by this guide. The table shows the parts of a typical report of about 6,000 to 8,000 words; shorter reports compress the same parts, and longer ones expand them, without changing the order.

Part	Purpose	Typical share
Title page	Title, author, course, date	1 page
Abstract	Summary of the whole report	200-300 words
Contents	List of sections and page numbers	1 page
1. Introduction	Question, aims, site and significance	8-10%
2. Background	What is already known; the setting	10-12%
3. Methods	How the data were collected	15-20%
4. Findings	What was observed, with evidence	30-35%
5. Discussion	What the findings mean	12-15%
6. Conclusion	Answer, limits, recommendations	5-8%
References	Sources cited	As needed
Appendices	Instruments, logs, extra tables	As needed

9.1 What each part must contain

The introduction states the question and the aims, introduces the site in a few sentences, and explains why the study matters. The background chapter describes the setting in enough detail for the reader to picture it, and summarises what is already known about the topic, so that the findings can be judged against it. The methods chapter is the most important for trust: it must describe the site, the dates, the hours, the observation method, the interview guide, the ethical approval and the way data were organised, in enough detail for a reader to judge the quality of the evidence. The findings chapter presents the evidence, theme by theme, with quotations, counts and tables. The discussion interprets the findings, compares them with what was known, and admits the limits. The conclusion answers the question and states what should happen next.

9.2 Length and balance

The commonest structural fault in student field reports is an over-long background and an under-written findings chapter. The background is the easiest part to write, because it comes from books, and the findings are the hardest, because they come from the student's own evidence — so students write too much of the first and too

little of the second. Aim for the balance in the table: the findings chapter should be the longest part of the report, roughly a third of the whole. If the findings are short, the problem is usually in the fieldwork, not in the writing, and the honest response is to say so in the limitations section rather than to pad the background.

[ ] The report follows the standard structure in the required order.

[ ] The methods chapter would let a reader judge the evidence.

[ ] The findings chapter is the longest part of the report.

[ ] Every claim in the findings is tied to evidence shown in the report.

[ ] The conclusion answers the question stated in the introduction.

Chapter 10: Writing Up Observations: Evidence, Not Impressions

The findings chapter is where fieldwork becomes a report, and its governing rule is simple: show the evidence, then say what you think it means — and make it clear which is which. A sentence that begins 'The researcher observed...' should be followed by evidence: a number, a quotation, a dated note. A sentence that begins 'This suggests...' is interpretation, and it should come after the evidence, not before it. Readers, and examiners, trust a report in which they can see the evidence for themselves and judge whether the interpretation follows from it.

10.1 Presenting observations clearly

Present each theme in its own section, with a clear heading. Begin the section with a short summary of the finding, then give the evidence: the counts, the quotations, the described events. Use the past tense for what happened and the present tense for what the evidence shows in general. Quote people sparingly and purposefully — a short quotation that shows a theme is worth more than a long one that repeats it. Give the source of every piece of evidence: the date, the place, the participant code or the counting sheet, so that the reader can see that the claim rests on a real observation and not on a general impression.

10.2 Using numbers honestly

Numbers in a field report are usually small: a few dozen interviews, a few hundred counted events. Report them plainly, with the denominators: '14 of the 20 patients interviewed said they waited more than an hour' is honest; 'most patients waited too long' is not. Do not turn small numbers into percentages that imply precision — '70%' sounds exact when it rests on twenty people, and it hides the small sample. Do not present averages without the range: an average waiting time of 45 minutes means something different if the shortest wait was 10 minutes and the longest was two hours. And never present a number without saying how it was counted.

10.3 Separating observation from judgement

The most damaging fault in a field report is presenting a judgement as if it were an

observation. 'The staff were lazy' is a judgement. 'Three of the five staff on duty spent more than half the morning away from the reception desk on two of the four days observed' is an observation that a reader can check against the notes. The report may go on to discuss what the observation might mean, but the observation itself must stand clean. A useful test, applied sentence by sentence while revising: could another person who was there agree or disagree with this sentence on the basis of what happened? If not, the sentence is an impression, and it needs evidence or deletion.

Worked Example: Evidence first, interpretation second

Weak: 'The market was unfair to poor customers, who were clearly exploited by greedy sellers.' No evidence is given, and the judgement is the writer's own. Strong: 'On 4 March, tomatoes were sold at 120 per kilo to the first customer and 100 per kilo to the third, after bargaining (Field notes, 4 March, 09:10-09:40). The same pattern — a higher opening price followed by a bargained reduction — was observed in 11 of 15 transactions that morning. This suggests that price depends on bargaining skill, which may disadvantage customers who bargain less confidently.' Evidence first, interpretation second, and the interpretation is hedged.

- [ ] Each finding begins with a short summary, followed by evidence.
- [ ] Every quotation and number is sourced by date and place or code.
- [ ] Numbers are given with denominators and ranges, not vague words.
- [ ] Judgements are written as interpretation, after the evidence.
- [ ] The sentence-by-sentence test has been applied while revising.

Chapter 11: Photographs, Maps and Sketches

A field report is read, not visited, so the reader needs help to picture the place. Photographs, maps and sketches supply that help, and they are also evidence in their own right: a photograph of a market layout, a sketch of a classroom, a map of a riverbank. But visual material only works if it is chosen, labelled and discussed. A report with twenty unexplained photographs is no better than a report with none; a report with five well-chosen, captioned and discussed images is much stronger than either.

11.1 Photographs: what to take and how to use them

Photograph the setting, not only the people: the layout of a room, the arrangement of stalls, the condition of equipment, the notice board, the queue. Take photographs at the start of fieldwork, so that the setting is recorded before you become used to it and stop noticing it. Take each photograph with a purpose — to show a layout, to record a detail, to illustrate a finding — and note the date, place, subject and direction in your log. In the report, give every photograph a number and a caption that says what it shows and why it matters, and refer to it in the text: 'Photograph 3 shows the single entrance through which all patients arrived.' Never use a photograph to decorate a page; if it does not support a point, leave it out.

11.2 Maps and sketches

A simple map or sketch is often more useful than a photograph, because it can show the whole site at a glance and label what matters. Draw a sketch map of the site early in fieldwork: the entrances, the main areas, the places where key activities happen, and a north arrow and a rough scale. Update it as your understanding grows. In the report, include the map near the start of the findings or the methods chapter, so that the reader can follow the descriptions that come later. A sketch need not be beautiful; it needs to be accurate, labelled and legible. If you use a published map, cite its source and obtain permission where required.

11.3 Permissions and presentation

Photographs of people require the same consent as interviews: ask first, explain the purpose, and accept a refusal. Do not photograph children without the permission of a parent or guardian and the institution responsible. In the report, do not publish a photograph that could identify a person who has not consented, and consider whether faces should be blurred even where consent was given for observation but not for publication. Present visual material well: keep images large enough to read, place each one close to the text that discusses it, and list all figures in the contents. A photograph that cannot be read is worse than no photograph at all.

[ ] Photographs show the setting and support specific points.

[ ] Every image has a number, a caption and a reference in the text.

[ ] A sketch map of the site is included, with a north arrow and labels.

[ ] Consent was obtained for every photograph showing an identifiable person.

[ ] Images are large enough to read and placed near the text that discusses them.

Chapter 12: Worked Example: A Complete Fictional Field Report

This chapter is a worked example. Everything in it is fictional: the place, the people, the numbers and the quotations are invented to show how a field report is put together. No real place or person is described. The example follows the structure of Chapter 9, and it shows how observation, counting, interviews and reflection combine into a report that an examiner can trust. Read it as a model of form, not as a source of facts.

12.1 The study in brief

Title: 'Morning Trading in a Neighbourhood Vegetable Market: A Field Study of Price-Setting by Bargaining'. The fictional researcher spent ten weekday mornings, from 08:00 to 11:00, in a small neighbourhood vegetable market, observing fifteen stalls. The research question was: how do sellers set and change their prices during the first hours of trading? The methods were non-participant observation with a structured counting sheet, plus eight short interviews with sellers and six with customers. Permission was obtained in writing from the market committee, and all

participants were given codes.

12.2 What the fictional data showed

The counting sheets recorded 148 transactions over the ten mornings. In 121 of them, the seller named an opening price and the final price was lower after bargaining; in 27, the first price was accepted without discussion. The average reduction after bargaining was about one sixth of the opening price, and the reduction was larger in the first hour than in the third, when most produce had been sold and prices were firmer. Interviews suggested a reason: sellers opened high because they expected bargaining, and they lowered prices late in the morning to clear stock before it spoiled. Customers who bought regularly at the same stall reported smaller reductions than first-time buyers, because, as one seller put it, 'I know her, she knows me, we do not waste time.'

12.3 How the findings were written up

The findings chapter of the fictional report presented the counts first, in a table, then illustrated them with three short observations written as dated field notes, and then reported the interview explanations. The discussion compared the pattern with the general idea that markets have fixed prices, and argued that in this market the price was not a label but the outcome of a short negotiation. The limitations were stated plainly: ten mornings in one market, in one season, cannot show how prices behave in other markets or at other times of year, and the researcher could not observe the wholesale prices the sellers had paid. The recommendations were modest: the market committee could display a guide price for the day, so that new customers would know the usual range; and a future study could compare morning and evening trading.

Worked Example: From field note to findings paragraph

Field note (fictional): 'Day 6, 08:40. Stall 4. Customer asked the price of onions. Seller said 90. Customer offered 60. Agreed at 75 after about a minute.' Findings paragraph: 'Bargaining was the normal way prices were set. In 121 of 148 transactions observed, the final price was lower than the opening price, with an average reduction of about one sixth. The process was usually short — a minute or two — and was described by sellers as a normal part of trading rather than a dispute.' The paragraph keeps the evidence and the interpretation in that order, and it names the source of the numbers.

12.4 What the example is meant to teach

Four lessons carry over from this fictional study to any real one. First, a narrow question and a fixed time window made the fieldwork manageable: ten mornings, one question, one market. Second, counting and interviewing answered different parts of the question, and neither alone would have been enough. Third, the report was honest about its limits, and the honesty made the findings more believable, not less. Fourth, the report gave the reader the evidence — the counts, the notes, the quotations — so that the reader could judge the interpretation rather than taking it on trust. Those four habits, practised on a small scale, are the whole craft of field

reporting.

[ ] The fictional example is labelled as fictional wherever it appears.

[ ] Counts, notes and interviews are all used, each for what it does best.

[ ] Findings are presented before interpretation, with sources named.

[ ] Limitations are stated plainly and recommendations follow from the findings.

Chapter 13: Common Mistakes and a Checklist

Fieldwork is learned by doing, and most students make the same mistakes the first time. The mistakes below are the ones supervisors see most often, and every one of them can be avoided with the planning and habits described in this guide. Read this chapter before you enter the field, not only before you submit: by submission time, the fieldwork mistakes are already made.

13.1 The ten most common mistakes

- Entering the field without a written question, and collecting material that answers nothing.
- Starting observations before permission has been obtained, and having to stop or discard the work.
- Mixing description and opinion in the notes, so that months later the evidence cannot be separated from the judgement.
- Writing notes days late, from memory, and losing the details that mattered.
- Asking leading questions in interviews, and recording the answers you suggested rather than the answers people would have given.
- Changing the counting categories halfway through fieldwork, so early and late data cannot be compared.
- Losing data: no backup, no labelled files, a notebook with no date on the pages.
- Writing a findings chapter that is mostly opinion, with little evidence shown.
- Claiming more than the evidence supports — generalising from one site to a whole country.
- Hiding the limitations, instead of stating them and explaining what they mean for the findings.

13.2 The final checklist

Work through this checklist with the finished report and the field notes side by side. Tick each item only when you have checked it on the page, not from memory.

[ ] The research question is stated in the introduction and answered in the conclusion.

[ ] Permission and ethical approval are described in the methods chapter.

[ ] Dates, hours, site and methods are given in enough detail to judge the evidence.

[ ] Field notes are dated, descriptive and separated from reflection.

[ ] Every finding is supported by evidence shown in the report: counts, quotations or dated notes.

[ ] Numbers are given with denominators and the method of counting is stated.

[ ] Photographs, maps and sketches are numbered, captioned and discussed.

[ ] Limitations are stated honestly with their consequences for the findings.

[ ] Recommendations follow from specific findings.

[ ] No real person is identifiable without their consent.

[ ] Page numbers, headings and the table of contents match.

[ ] The report has been proofread, and the file is backed up in a second location.

Chapter 14: Conclusion

Fieldwork is the most demanding and the most rewarding part of many students' research. It is demanding because it cannot be done from a desk: it requires planning, patience, good notes and honest writing. It is rewarding because it produces knowledge that no book can give — knowledge of how things actually happen, in a real place, among real people. A student who has done fieldwork well has learned something that stays useful far beyond the thesis: how to watch carefully, how to listen, how to record faithfully, and how to write so that a reader who was not there can trust what is claimed.

The habits in this guide are simple, and they are the whole method. Plan before you go, and get permission first. Watch systematically, and write your notes the same day. Keep description and reflection apart. Ask fair questions, and listen to the answers. Organise your material as you collect it, and back it up every evening. Analyse by testing patterns against the evidence, not by choosing the evidence that fits. Write the report with the evidence first and the interpretation second, and state the limits honestly. Do that, and your field report will be what a field report should be: a clear, checkable account of something real, written by someone who was there.

Suggested Reading

The following are general kinds of works that students commonly consult for fieldwork. Check your university library for the latest editions, and follow your department's guidance on referencing style.

- Standard research methods textbooks: general methodology texts used in most universities cover observation, interviewing, field notes and qualitative analysis, with chapters on design and ethics.
- Guides to ethnography and participant observation: widely used introductory works explain how to enter a field site, take part in daily life, and write about it without losing critical distance.
- Guides to qualitative data analysis: standard works on coding, thematic analysis and triangulation show how to move from raw notes and transcripts to defensible findings.
- Your university's fieldwork handbook and ethics guidance: the first authority on

permissions, consent forms, risk assessment and safety procedures for your own department.

- Your supervisor's recommended reading list for your subject: the most relevant source of all, because it is chosen for your specific topic and field site.